

How to Build Your Own AI Voice Agent with Bolna

A Step by Step Guide to Creating Automated Phone Agents

What is Bolna AI?

Bolna is a platform that lets you create AI voice agents that can make and receive phone calls. These agents can handle appointment bookings, customer support, lead qualification, and more. Think of it as building a smart assistant that talks to people on your behalf.

What You Need Before Starting

- A Bolna AI account (sign up at bolna.ai)
- ChatGPT Plus subscription (for creating a Custom GPT)
- Cal.com account if you want appointment booking
- Basic understanding of how APIs work (helpful but not required)

Step 1: Create Your Agent in Bolna

Log into your Bolna dashboard and click on "Create Agent". You will need to configure three main components:

Voice Selection

Choose the voice provider (like ElevenLabs or PlayHT) and select a voice that matches your brand. You can preview different voices before committing.

Language Model

Select the AI model that will power your agent's intelligence. GPT-4 is recommended for complex conversations, while GPT-3.5 works well for simpler use cases and costs less.

Transcription

Choose your speech to text provider. Deepgram is a solid choice for accuracy and speed.

Step 2: Download Agent Prompts from Bolna

This is where Bolna makes your life easier. Instead of writing prompts from scratch:

1. Go to the Bolna marketplace or templates section
2. Browse through pre-built agent templates (appointment booking, lead qualification, customer support, etc.)
3. Download the prompt template that matches your use case
4. Review the structure to understand how professional voice agent prompts are written

These templates give you a solid foundation. They include conversation flows, handling objections, and proper formatting that voice agents need.

Step 3: Create a Custom GPT for Prompt Generation

Now here is where it gets interesting. Instead of manually editing prompts every time, create a Custom GPT that generates Bolna compatible prompts for you.

How to Set This Up

5. Open ChatGPT and go to "Create a GPT"
6. In the Instructions section, paste the Bolna prompt template you downloaded
7. Add instructions telling the GPT to use this as a reference format
8. Tell it to ask for business details (company name, service offered, booking preferences, etc.)
9. Save your Custom GPT

Now whenever you need a new voice agent prompt, just chat with your Custom GPT. Tell it what the agent should do, and it will generate a properly formatted prompt that you can copy directly into Bolna.

Step 4: Configure Your Agent's Behavior

Back in Bolna, paste your generated prompt into the Agent Prompt section. Then configure:

- **Welcome message:** What the agent says when it answers or makes a call
- **End call phrases:** Words that trigger the agent to hang up (like "goodbye" or "not interested")
- **Interruption handling:** How the agent responds when someone talks over it
- **Max call duration:** Safety limit to prevent endless calls

Step 5: Add Functions (Optional but Powerful)

Functions let your agent take real actions during calls. The most common one is appointment booking.

Connecting Cal.com for Appointments

10. Get your Cal.com API key from Settings
11. In Bolna, add a new function
12. Configure the API endpoint and parameters
13. Test the booking flow

When someone wants to book during a call, your agent can check availability and create the appointment in real time.

Step 6: Get a Phone Number and Test

14. In Bolna, go to Phone Numbers and purchase one (or connect your Twilio number)
15. Link the number to your agent
16. Make a test call to your number
17. Review the call transcript and recordings
18. Refine your prompt based on how the conversation went

Pro Tips for Better Voice Agents

- **Keep responses short:** Long monologues sound robotic. Aim for 2 to 3 sentences max before pausing.
- **Use natural language:** Write prompts the way people actually talk, not how they write.
- **Handle silence:** Add instructions for what to do if the caller goes quiet.
- **Test with real scenarios:** Try to break your agent by asking unexpected questions.
- **Review transcripts:** Your best improvements come from reading actual conversations.

Quick Reference

Step	Action
Create Agent	Set up voice, model, and transcription in Bolna
Get Templates	Download prompt templates from Bolna marketplace

Build Custom GPT	Create a GPT trained on Bolna prompt format
Configure	Set welcome message, end phrases, interruptions
Add Functions	Connect Cal.com or other APIs for actions
Test and Refine	Call your agent, review transcripts, improve

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